

GRADUALLY REDUCING YOUR PHOBIC FEAR

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Identify precisely what the feared object or situation is.
2. Describe the emotional, physiological, and behavioral impact that the feared object or situation has had.
3. Develop and implement a plan of systematic exposure to the feared object or situation until fear is extinguished.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Childhood Trauma
- Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)
- Social Discomfort

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

Systematic desensitization to a phobic object or situation has proven to be a very successful approach to extinguishing a fear response. This assignment focuses the client on the phobic stimulus and its effect on his/her life. Then, the client must develop a gradual hierarchy of exposure steps to the feared stimulus. You probably will have to be directly involved in constructing this hierarchy with the client. As preparation for beginning the *in vivo* exposure to the feared stimulus, it is recommended that you teach the client some behavioral and cognitive anxiety-reduction skills, such as deep breathing, progressive relaxation, positive imagery, confidence-building self-talk, and so on. Monitor and reinforce his/her implementation of these skills as the exposure program progresses. Urge the patient to increase exposure as anxiety diminishes to the current step.

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Fears that are so strong that they control our behavior need to be faced and overcome. This exercise helps you do just that: Identify what your fear is; describe how it affects you; develop a plan to face it systematically; and, finally, actually take steps to face your fear and win.

1. It is important to clearly identify what you fear and how it affects you emotionally (e.g., feel nervous and tense), behaviorally (such as avoid contact and/or don't talk about the feared stimulus), and physically (for instance, heart pounds, forehead and palms sweat, stomachache, nausea). Describe what the feared object or situation is and then tell how it affects you.

Feared Object or Situation

Reaction to Feared Object or SituationEmotional reaction:

Behavioral reaction:

Physical reaction:

To overcome a fear, it must be faced in a gradual but systematic fashion. We call this *exposure*. When you practice exposure in the proper way, fear steadily diminishes until it does not control your behavior or affect you physically. The key to the process is to develop a plan for gradually increasing exposure to the feared object or situation. Once the plan is developed, you then expose yourself one step at a time to the feared object or situation. You do not take the next step in the gradual exposure plan until you are quite comfortable with the current level of exposure.

For example, if your fear is that of driving alone on the expressway during heavy traffic, you could design a plan as follows.

Step 1. Drive on the expressway for 5 minutes at a time of light traffic with a supportive person to give reassurance.

Step 2: Drive on the expressway for 5 minutes at a time of light traffic, alone.

Step 3: Drive on the expressway for 10 minutes at a time of light traffic, alone.

Step 4: Drive on the expressway for 15 minutes at a time of light traffic, alone.

Step 5: Drive on the expressway for 5 minutes at a time of heavy traffic, alone.

Step 6: Drive on the expressway for 15 minutes at a time of heavy traffic, alone.

Each next step is taken only after the fear is low or gone in the current step.

2. Now create a gradual exposure program to overcome your feared object or situation. The steps can increase the time you spend with the feared object or situation, increase your closeness to it, increase the size of the object, or a combination of these things. Use as many steps as you need. Your therapist is available to help you construct this plan, if necessary.

Step 1. _____

Step 2. _____

Step 3. _____

Step 4. _____

Step 5. _____

Step 6. _____

Now it's time for a gradual but steady exposure to your feared object or situation. Stay relaxed. Your therapist may teach you some deep breathing, muscle relaxation, and positive self-talk techniques that you can use to keep yourself relaxed. For each attempt at exposure, record the coping technique you used and rate your degree of fear on a scale of 1 to 100, with 100 representing total panic, the sweats, and heart-pounding shakes. The rating of 1 represents total calm, complete confidence, peace of mind, looseness, and relaxed feeling. When your rating is reduced to 10 or lower on a consistent basis for the exposure to a particular step, then it's time to consider moving on to the next step.

Exposure Steps

Step 1. _____

Step 2. _____

Step 3. _____

Step 4. _____

Step 5. _____

Step 6. _____

Coping Technique and Fear Rating

1st attempt: _____

2nd attempt: _____

3rd attempt: _____

1st attempt: _____

2nd attempt: _____

3rd attempt: _____

1st attempt: _____

2nd attempt: _____

3rd attempt: _____

1st attempt: _____

2nd attempt: _____

3rd attempt: _____

1st attempt: _____

2nd attempt: _____

3rd attempt: _____

1st attempt: _____

2nd attempt: _____

3rd attempt: _____